

Setting up ChatGPT

A no-nonsense start. Ten minutes, not a course.

1. Create your account

Go to chatgpt.com and sign up, email or Google, Microsoft or Apple all work. Free tier starts immediately, no card needed.

2. Fix the defaults that trip people up

Settings, then Data Controls. Two toggles worth knowing about straight away: "Improve the model for everyone" (whether your chats can be used to train future versions) and Chat History & Training. If you'd rather your conversations weren't used that way, turn it off now, before you've put anything real into it.

3. Turn on memory properly

Settings, then Personalization, then Memory. This is what lets ChatGPT remember things about you between conversations instead of starting cold every time, your job, your preferences, whatever you're working on. Turn it on, and check back here occasionally, you can see and delete exactly what it's remembered.

4. Set custom instructions

Settings, then Personalization, then Custom Instructions. Two boxes: what you want it to know about you, and how you want it to respond. Fill both in properly once and every answer after that is shaped around you instead of generic. This is the single highest-leverage five minutes you can spend setting this tool up.

5. One thing to actually try today

Ask it something real, using your own situation, not a demo question. "Help me [an actual task]." See what comes back before you touch another setting.
